Novel Writing

Advanced 400-Level Elective for
Creative Writing majors



Proposal

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EXECUTIVE *SUMMARY*

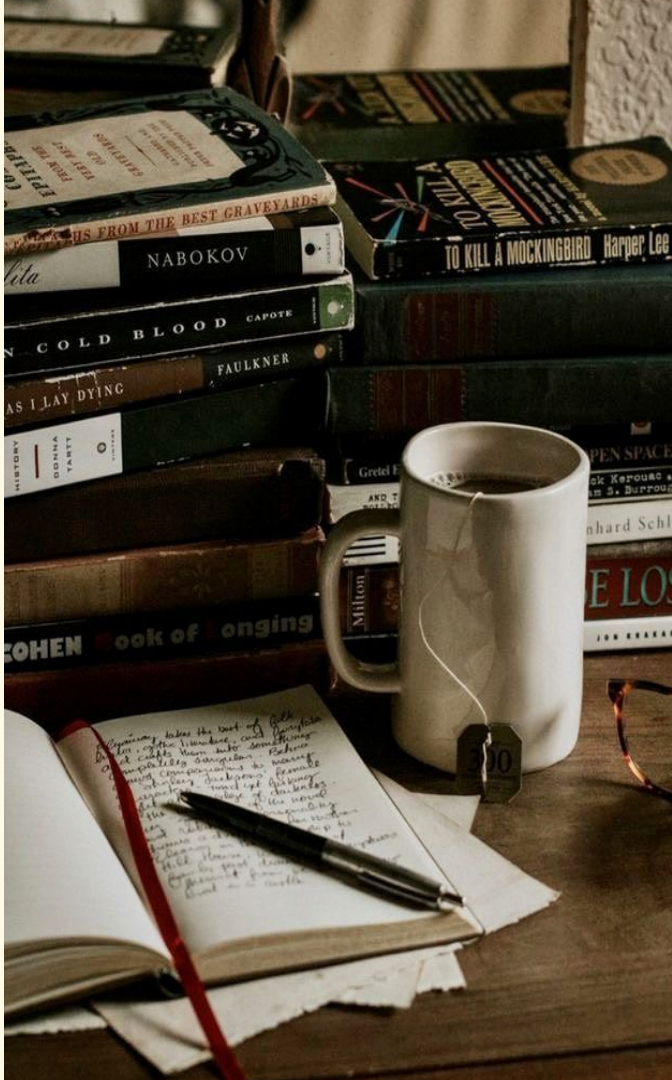
Emerging writers are often told that writing a novel is no easy feat. Yet they are rarely taught what makes the process so challenging, or how to navigate its demands. While Concordia University's Creative Writing program helps students "approach literature from a writer's point of view as [they] develop [their] own craft" (Concordia University, 2026), there remains an opportunity to provide a more structured guidance in managing long-form projects, so the writers of today can become the authors of tomorrow.

Common mistakes when writing a first novel (McCreet, 2016, pp. 4-6)

- Unclear narrative POV
- Summarising over narrating
- Halting structure
- Weak premise
- Disconnected storyline
- Occurrence unevenly distributed
- Inconclusive endings
- "Most first-time novelists stumble because they are writing as readers" (McCreet 6)

Solution: ENGL 427 Novel Writing (6 credits)

The goal of this course is to equip students with the proper tools and skill sets to sustain an independent, long-term writing practice.

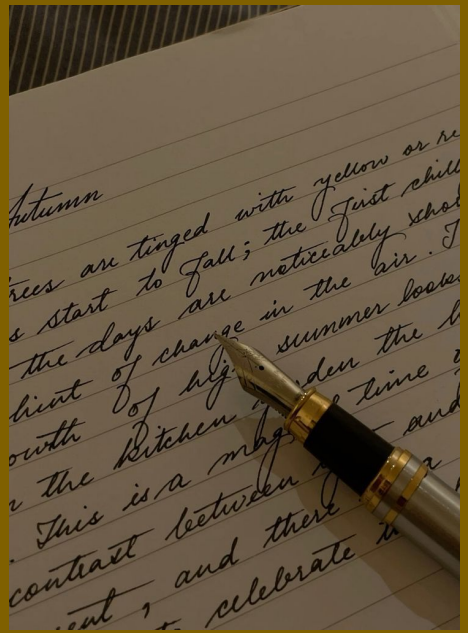


COURSE DESCRIPTION & *APPROACH*

Description

This advanced workshop is open to students who have completed at least 9 credits in Prose Fiction.

Through a year-long novel project, students will develop their skills in world-building, characterization, and plot development while learning to manage long-form writing projects and prepare manuscripts for publication pitches.

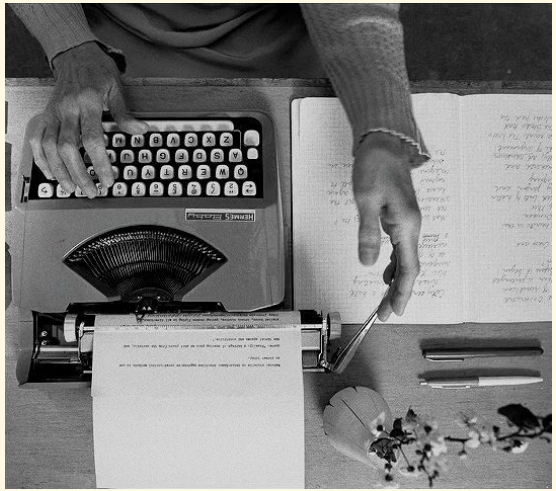


Course approach and details

ENGL 427 - Novel Writing (6 credits)

- An advanced elective for Creative Writing program
- Chairs available: 12-17
- Prerequisites: a minimum of 9 prose fiction credits
- Format: seminar/workshop with individual consultations.

COURSE DESCRIPTION & *APPROACH*



How it fits in the curriculum

2026-2027 existing classes and their offers:

- ENGL 226 Introductory to Prose Fiction: the fundamentals, and first workshop experiences
- ENGL 3420 Advanced studies in Creative Writing: classes divided into specialized topics (e.g. dialogue, characters, setting), only 3 credits each
- ENGL 414 Literary Publishing and Editing: publishing on a more physical approach (ex. bookbinding)
- ENGL 4180 Digital editing and publishing: focus on magazines and digital publishing

The programs offers cross-genre writing, experimental writing, flash fiction, and the long poem.

My proposal: An advanced workshop building on students' existing writing skills to help them develop a novel of any genre to complement this gap. It will teach them to write consistently and independently, and to stay organized throughout the length of this more ambitious and complex project.

Material covered / Syllabus

Outside of writing:

- Coming up with ideas that can sustain a novel-length story
- Researching
- Structural planning and note-keeping techniques + online resources and how to use them (ex. Obsidian)
- Learning how to prepare and pitch your manuscript for print publications

For writing:

- Writing synopses
- How to develop world-building, organize events chronologically, keep details consistent and cohesive, and build convincing settings
- Creating believable characterizations and character arcs
- How to perform strategic revision

JUSTIFICATION FEATURES

- Defining the problem
- Explaining the benefits & the risks
- Aligning with organizational goals

DEFINING THE *PROBLEM*

The current creative writing curriculum already provides instruction in prose writing, creative process, revision, and workshop practice.

The more specific concern is whether students have enough structured opportunities to apply those skills to the *long-term* development of a single novel project. Writing a novel requires additional skills, such as **maintaining narrative consistency, organizing research and story details, and managing long-term revisions**.

ENGL 427 help build skills relevant to a substantial segment of the current book market.







Curricular Evidence

ENGL 427 – Novel Writing would address these demands through a dedicated, year-long workshop that guides students from developing a novel to preparing a manuscript for pitching. It will not overstep on existing curriculum skills, but rather, fill the gap.

Market evidence

- There is still a high market demand for novels in the Canadian book market.
- A January 2026 report show that novel fiction is at its highest selling point with 1,052,808 volumes sold.
- Fiction and Juvenile/Young Adult books accounted for a combined 68% of Canadian print-book sales in 2024 (BookNet Canada, 2026).

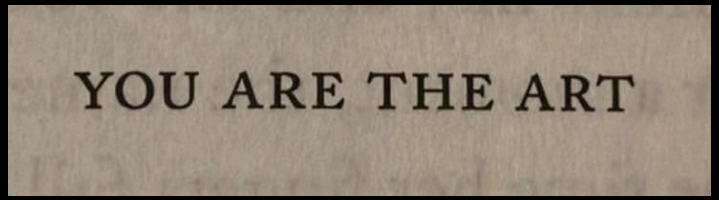
Student-demand evidence

- An assumption, based on my experience as a Creative Writing student at Concordia, is that many students are already working on personal manuscripts or aspire to publish novels. Conversations with students suggest a potential demand for more structured guidance in long-form fiction
- A Knox College survey found that 60% of surveyed Creative Writing graduates had become published authors (Chozen).

THE BENEFITS *& THE RISKS*

Benefits: better understanding of narrative writing, practical experience with long-form, greater independence, stronger ability to create complex stories, preparation for future endeavours, greater familiarity with publishing conventions and formats, project-management and communication skills.





Potential risks

01 **Warped expectations**: students might expect having a full novel in one year or securing a publishing deal = define achievable milestones

02 **Instructor workload:** need a balanced syllabus for theory and practice while navigating different student genres

03 **Cost-benefit:** Will a cap 12-17 enrollment encourage enough participation and class success that will be worth the investment?

ALIGNING WITH *ORGANIZATIONAL GOALS*

Concordia values/goals:

- Program innovations
- Research strengths
- Student Success
- Experiential learning
- Leadership & support

"A writer has to understand the mechanisms of a novel in advance in order to write it" (McCreet 7).



How my proposal aligns:

EXPERIENTIAL LEARNING

Workshops allow students to apply the craft and knowledge to an ongoing novel project rather than separate short stories. They receive closely curated feedback.

STUDENT SUCCESS

The course intends to equip students with the right tools to strengthen their independent writing, revising, critical thinking, and project managing skills for beyond the class

PROGRAM INNOVATION

By combining fiction-writing workshops with project management, sustained revision, and preparation of professional submission, ENGL 427 provides practical experience and equips students with transferable skills valuable to their careers

DEMOGRAPHIC *ASSESSMENT*

- Target audience
- Class sizes

TARGET *AUDIENCE*



01 PRIMARY TARGET

Creative writing students (major, minor, honours) who are interested in writing a novel or have already begun a novel-length project, regardless of genre.

Estimated engagement:
18,833 students in Faculty of Arts and Science ÷ 33 departments = 570 students/department.
570 students in English department ÷ 9 programs = 63 students/program
63 x 3 Creative writing programs ≈ 190 students

02 SECONDARY TARGET

Any another English department students (English literature, professional writing). Any qualified literary students who have the desire to write a book as an interest, with permission of the department and potentially submission of a brief portfolio required for acceptance.

Estimated engagement:
570 English department students

(Concordia 2026)

*__Disclaimer__: in the absence of program-specific enrolment data, an estimate was developed using university-wide enrolment figures. However, this estimate is indicative only, being as student enrolment is not distributed evenly across departments or programs

AVAILABLE *SEATS*

Class capacity: 12-17 students

The smaller class size will allow for more workshop time, more detailed feedback, and individualized assessments through one-on-one consultations with the professor.

Cross-listing?
ENGL 427 is a dedicated elective for Creative Writing students who have pursued fiction writing throughout their studies, rather than a cross-listed course. This ensures that eligible students interested in developing a novel have access to seats reserved for their program.



CONCLUSION

ENGL 427 Novel Writing would provide a **focused opportunity** for advanced Creative Writing students to **apply their existing knowledge of fiction to the development of a novel.** By combining narrative writing, project organization, structural revision, peer feedback, and publishing preparation, the course would **address a specific stage of the writing process that deserves consideration** within Concordia's broader commitment to program innovations, experiential learning, and student success.

- A course with a limit of 12–17 students would allow the Department of English to test student demand, evaluate learning outcomes, assess workload, and determine whether the course can be included in the curriculum.

- Concordia already provides a strong foundation in creative writing. The proposed course would build on that foundation by helping students move from learning the how to write fiction to managing the development of a novel as a bigger and longer professional effort.

- Preparing writers for the future means giving them not only the tools to begin a story, but also the knowledge and support to carry an ambitious project forward. ENGL 427 Novel Writing would put this objective into practice in the undergraduate program.

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